P12

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SmartNote

Summary

The meeting focused on a research study with 412 Food Rescue to design a fairer food donation allocation algorithm by eliciting a donor stakeholder's preferences. The participant completed a series of allocation scenarios, explained decision criteria, reflected on fairness, and provided feedback on the survey and on the role of expert organizations like 412 Food Rescue.

Key takeaway

Study Purpose and Context: Fair Allocation Algorithm

- **The session aimed to gather stakeholder preferences to help build a fairness-focused algorithm for allocating food donations for 412 Food Rescue.**

- The facilitator explained that 412 Food Rescue faces demand beyond staff capacity and is exploring a computer algorithm to assist the donation process while keeping allocations fair and equitable.
- The participant was told they would act in the role of 412 Food Rescue, choosing a recipient in 45 randomly generated donation scenarios to reveal their fairness preferences, which would then be aggregated into an algorithm.

Scenario Structure and Decision Factors

- **Allocation choices were based on structured comparison of recipients and donation characteristics.**

- Each scenario presented two potential recipient organizations with attributes such as organization size (e.g., under 50 vs. 1,000 people served per month), food access level (normal vs. low/food desert), area income level, poverty rate, travel time, last donation date, and recent donation history split into common vs. less common/high-demand items.
- The donation size was standardized to "whatever can fit in the back of a car," and donation types were categorized as common (about 70% of total, e.g., bread) versus less common/high-demand (about 30%).

Participant's Allocation Priorities and Patterns

- **The participant consistently prioritized poverty rate, income level, food access, organization size, and donation history over other factors like travel time.**

- They frequently chose the recipient with lower income and higher poverty rates, often explicitly citing "income level and poverty rate" as the main reason.
- Low food access or food desert status repeatedly drove choices toward a given recipient ("because of the level of food access").
- Organization size (ability to serve more people) was a key factor, with the participant selecting organizations they believed would "put the food to better use" based on size.
- Donation history mattered, especially when a recipient had "never received anything before" or had not received a donation in a long time, and the participant described an interest in balancing last donation time and total donations received.
- The participant commented that they "really don't care about the travel time," indicating logistics were less important than need-based criteria in their fairness judgment.

Donor Role and Relationship with 412 Food Rescue

- **The participant described their organization's donor role and connection with 412 Food Rescue.**

- They work in university dining services, operating food services for students and staff.
- A student group affiliated with them conducts daily recoveries and coordinates with 412 Food Rescue to determine where food is sent, and large end-of-year recoveries (around a thousand pounds) occur when the school closes.
- The participant agreed to share contact information for this student group with the researchers.

Perception of Fairness and Role of Expertise

- **The participant viewed fair allocation as matching donations to recipients' and clients' needs, guided by expert knowledge from organizations like 412 Food Rescue.**

- They defined a fair allocation as one that understands recipients' and clients' needs and uses available resources to best meet those needs.
- They expressed that they had assumed 412 Food Rescue "would have a better judgment" on where food should go, given its local expertise in needs across service areas.
- As a donor, they stated they want their food to go where it is most needed but do not feel equipped to know where that is across the wider region, reinforcing their reliance on 412 Food Rescue and local food security experts.

Feedback on Survey Experience and Data Needs

- **The participant found the decision process impersonal and suggested additional data would improve judgments.**

- They described the process as "very impersonal" and noted it would be helpful to know how well previous donations were utilized, recipients' capacity to distribute different types of food, and how receptive clients were to specific items.
- They assumed the survey was focused on "easily accessible factors" that might influence where food goes, and questioned the relative importance of their own opinion compared to that of recipients and service providers.
- They indicated that, in their view, recipients and local service providers (like 412 Food Rescue and food security experts) should have the most influential voice in defining fair allocation criteria.

Incentive Distribution

- **The meeting concluded with incentive selection for participation.**

- The participant chose an Amazon gift card as a thank-you for completing the survey and provided a signature to confirm receipt.

Action Items

- [ ] Donor (University Dining Services Representative) -> Provide contact information for the student group that coordinates daily food recoveries with 412 Food Rescue (no due date)

Chapters

Introducción al propósito del estudio
El interlocutor explica el contexto del estudio con la organización 412 Food Rescue, mencionando su éxito reciente y el crecimiento de la demanda que supera su capacidad. Indica que están desarrollando un algoritmo informático para hacer el proceso de donación más justo y eficiente. Se aclara que se busca entender qué consideran los participantes una distribución justa, mediante la selección de ganadores en 45 escenarios de donación.
2s

Descripción del proceso del ejercicio de elección
El facilitador detalla que al inicio las decisiones serán más lentas, pero que se agilizarán con la práctica. Explica que se utilizarán datos de preferencias para diseñar el algoritmo y que los receptores A y B tienen distintos factores asociados a las donaciones. Además, se presentan los diferentes tipos de donaciones, clasificadas como comunes o de alta demanda.
45s

Factores de evaluación de los receptores
Se detallan los factores que influyen en la asignación: tipo de donación, tamaño del receptor, acceso a alimentos, nivel de ingresos, tasa de pobreza, tiempo de traslado, última donación y cantidad total recibida. El facilitador muestra ejemplos y porcentajes de donaciones comunes (70%) y menos comunes (30%) para explicar cómo se toman las decisiones.
1m 50s

Inicio de la selección de receptores y criterios del participante
Comenzando el ejercicio, el participante pregunta por el volumen de las donaciones. El facilitador aclara que todas caben en un automóvil. El participante elige entre los receptores A o B basándose principalmente en el nivel de pobreza, acceso a alimentos, tamaño de la organización y antecedentes de donaciones, indicando las razones de sus elecciones repetidamente durante numerosos escenarios.
3m 48s

Discusión sobre la historia de donaciones y factores clave
El participante continúa explicando sus elecciones entre receptores A y B. Menciona de forma consistente factores como acceso a alimentos, ingresos, tasa de pobreza, tamaño organizacional e historial de donaciones recientes como motivos principales. También comenta que el tiempo de transporte no influye mucho en sus decisiones y aclara que considera la historia de donaciones para equilibrar la distribución.
17m 14s

Preguntas de perfil del donante y relación con 412 Food Rescue
El facilitador pregunta acerca del papel del participante como donante y sobre su organización. El participante explica que pertenece a los servicios de comidas de la universidad y que colaboran con un grupo estudiantil que realiza recuperaciones diarias con 412 Food Rescue, incluyendo donaciones grandes al final del año académico.
20m 3s

Reflexiones sobre el proceso de toma de decisiones
El facilitador pregunta cómo se sintió el participante durante el proceso. Este comenta que fue impersonal y que hubiera sido útil conocer la utilización de donaciones anteriores por parte de los receptores y su capacidad para distribuir los alimentos según las necesidades locales.
22m 11s

Opinión sobre lo que significa una asignación justa
Ante la pregunta de qué sería una asignación justa, el participante responde que aquella que entiende las necesidades de receptores y clientes, y usa los recursos para satisfacerlas de la mejor manera posible.
23m 3s

Percepción sobre quienes deben decidir las asignaciones
El participante expresa que considera que las opiniones más importantes son las de los proveedores de servicio y los expertos en seguridad alimentaria, no tanto las de los donantes. Menciona su confianza en que 412 Food Rescue conoce mejor las necesidades locales y debería decidir la asignación de los recursos.
23m 44s

Cierre del encuentro y agradecimiento
El facilitador agradece al participante, le ofrece una tarjeta de regalo como compensación y concluye la sesión.
25m 3s

Transcript

SPEAKER 1
So to give you some context, the reason why I'm here so for the past two years, four one two Food Rescue has seen significant success, but the demand for their service has increased beyond their staff capacity, and they are seeking more efficient alternatives. We are partnering with organizations to build a computer algorithm to assist the donation process. One of our goal is to keep donation location fair and equitable. As part of a research, we're talking to stakeholders like yourselves to learn what you think is a fair allocation because there's no one right answer when it comes to making a fair algorithm. To learn what you think is is fair, we will ask you to pick the winning recipient in series of 45 donation scenarios.

SPEAKER 1
This will take a longer time in the beginning. However, we guarantee it will go faster once you get used to the flow of it. Once we learn your preferences, we will aggregate the fairness preferences to design a computer algorithm. So what we will be doing today, we have this randomly generated recipients. So recipient a has different factors.

SPEAKER 1
B has different factors. And this is the incoming donation type. So I'm gonna go through all the factors. So the incoming donation well, actually, kind of taking a step back, like, you will be playing the role of phone to food rescue. And deciding Mhmm.

SPEAKER 1
Who does receives what. And so the incoming donation divides into common donations and less common and high demand donations.

SPEAKER 2
Mhmm.

SPEAKER 1
Common donations, which could be producer bread, which takes up 70% of total donations donations currently, or it could be less common in high demand donations, which take up 30% of the total donations. Recipients vary in their sizes. So for example, here, persistent a serves less than 50 people a month versus b serves a thousand people a

SPEAKER 2
month. Mhmm.

SPEAKER 1
They also vary in level of foot access. So Wow. A has normal foot access versus b has low foot access, which, like, if they are lower extremity level, they are considered a foot desert. Right. Income levels also vary.

SPEAKER 1
So this is concerning the income level of where the clients reside in. Mhmm. So if this pantry serves three ZIP codes, this is the average income of those three ZIP codes. And, also, this is the poverty rate of the area where they reside.

SPEAKER 2
That's a lot of factors.

SPEAKER 1
Mhmm. It is a lot. Okay. The travel time is how long it takes the volunteer to take the food from the donor to the recipient. Last donation is when they receive the last.

SPEAKER 1
And the total donation is how much they've received in the past three months, and that divides also into, like for example, it could be like this where the blue is the common donation they received, and then the light blue is the less common. Okay. So that will help you kinda decide, like, which one population of it. Mhmm. Okay.

SPEAKER 1
So we'll just go through, like, 45 of these. Okay. Yeah. It'll get faster because you'll start to build, like, your own preferences.

SPEAKER 2
Okay.

SPEAKER 1
Yeah. And it'll be really helpful if you could kinda tell us, like, briefly why you chose a or b every time you select it. Yeah. And so this would be the first question.

SPEAKER 2
This is the first one. Mhmm. It doesn't it doesn't say the volume of the food donation type?

SPEAKER 1
Oh, yes. The donation

SPEAKER 2
Like, you know, if it's, like, 2,500 pounds versus 30 pounds.

SPEAKER 1
The donation is for our scenario. We're just saying that whatever it can fit in the back of a car.

SPEAKER 2
Oh, okay. For a car. Okay. Okay. I'd probably pick recipient b E.

SPEAKER 2
Because recipient a's income level and access to food puts them at it pretty and their poverty rate is very low. So I don't seem to be as much of a mean. So Probably the hire us

SPEAKER 1
if Yes. Party

SPEAKER 2
gets graduates.

SPEAKER 1
Was there a particular reason for this one? Or

SPEAKER 2
Again, recipient high level of income despite being low level of food access. They seem to be in a better place than recipient b. Mhmm. That closes the door. Yep.

SPEAKER 2
B as well. Mhmm. Again, I think income level, poverty rate were the biggest factors. Probably recipient a because the the organization size Mhmm. Seems like the food would be put better to use there as well as the income level.

SPEAKER 2
Probably b because of low food access. Probably b because they've never received anything before. Also, b, because they haven't received anything before. B, because of the food access and common poppy rape. B, because of income level and the donations received.

SPEAKER 2
B, because they haven't received a donation in a while. A because they've never received a donation and a higher property for lower income level. B, because of income level poverty rate and the history of no donation. Probably, a, because they don't really receive a common donation that much. A, because of the level of food access and income and poverty.

SPEAKER 2
Because of possible food access income in poverty. B, because of the level of food access. B, because of the local food access and the past donations. B, because of the food access and poverty rate. B, because of poverty and income level and no donations in the past.

SPEAKER 2
B, because of the size of the organization, the poverty rate
you access.

SPEAKER 1
Oh my.

SPEAKER 2
A, because of the difference in food access and the last donation they received. A, because of food access and donation's history, b, because of the level of food access and POPE rate. A, because of the level of access to POPE rate and the donation history. Because of the organization's size and level of food access. B, because of the organization size, poverty rating, level of food access.

SPEAKER 2
A, because of poverty rate and the past donations. B, because of level of food access and the poverty rate. B, because of the past donations of organization size. A, because of the organization size and income level. That changed.

SPEAKER 2
I think it's the same one. Same one. Yeah. A, because of poverty rate and organization size. I really don't care about the travel time, it seems.

SPEAKER 2
A, because of the organization size, level of food access, and history of donations. B, because of the level of food access of coffee. Right? Maybe because of the level of food access and the organization size. Well, I guess those are the same.

SPEAKER 2
So, A, because of the income level, food access, the organization size. A, because of the organization size, poverty, and poverty rate.

SPEAKER 1
What was it? A. Sorry.

SPEAKER 2
B, because of organization size and donation history. A, because of the poverty rate, low food access.

SPEAKER 1
When you say donation history, is it to kinda, like, equal out, or is it?

SPEAKER 2
Yeah. These two just seem to be, like, they like, that the the the last donation time Mhmm. As well as the combination of what the makeup of those donations were. Mhmm. I can be more specific and say last donation, total donation received.

SPEAKER 2
Mhmm. Okay. B, because of the poverty rate, A, because of the level of food access. A, because of total donations received in the recipient organization size. B, because of the level of access organization size.

SPEAKER 1
I think can go, like, four more. Yeah.

SPEAKER 2
B, because of the poverty rate. A, because of the organization size. B, because of the organization life. B, because of poverty level food access. A, because of poverty rate level food access.

SPEAKER 2
So

SPEAKER 1
we just have a few questions about the survey. Also, actually, I have an s, but, like, you you are a donor. Right? Mhmm. Donor.

SPEAKER 1
What exactly is the organization?

SPEAKER 2
So this is the dining services for the university. Mhmm. So we operate, you know, all the food services for the students and the staff.

SPEAKER 1
And how often do you donate to four one two?

SPEAKER 2
We have a student group Mhmm. That works with four one two, so we could maybe see it as an extension of four one two, like the local chapters, maybe say. So they do recoveries every day. They do a lot of so they work with four zero one two to find out where to send the food to. Mhmm.

SPEAKER 2
But they're recovering every day.

SPEAKER 1
I see.

SPEAKER 2
But then we also do at the end of the year big recoveries, like a thousand pounds or something when the school shuts down and the students are gone. Do

SPEAKER 1
you know, like, how we might be able to get in contact with the student group?

SPEAKER 2
Yeah. I'll definitely give

SPEAKER 1
you the information. Yeah. That'll be good. So about the survey, is this something that you thought about as of how decisions are made? Or

SPEAKER 2
I always thought that I I just kinda figured that four one two would have a better judgment about who the food should be delivered to because they're more of the experts in the area. They know the the needs for the different locations better than than meat would.

SPEAKER 1
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That's kind of what their role is to figure out where to put the food. Mhmm.

SPEAKER 1
How how did you feel about the whole process of making decisions?

SPEAKER 2
It was very impersonal. You know, I I guess it would have been nice to know how much of the previous donations were actually utilized or preferred. Right? So if the recipient was had the capacity to distribute the different types of foods and donations Mhmm. And how receptive their their clients were.

SPEAKER 2
Mhmm.

SPEAKER 1
In your opinion, what does a fair allocation look like?

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One that understands the needs of the recipient and the clients and tries their best to leverage what they have to meet those needs. When it doesn't well yeah. Okay.

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Do you have any suggestions or any other ways you could see of doing this or anything that was unclear to you today?

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SPEAKER 2
Experts in local food security would be the most important ones.

SPEAKER 1
Yeah. So you're kind of in the position as a donor. Right? So to you, it's more like since they are the expert station at this side where Yeah.

SPEAKER 2
I don't want my yeah. I don't really I would love my food to go where it's needed the most. Mhmm. But I don't know where it's needed the most. That's not part of my daily job to understand, you know, in the entire Southwestern the region where they, you know, service things, a sixty minute radius from here where the needs are.

SPEAKER 2
Mhmm. So that's why I think Ford too has that's where their strength is that assume they know the needs of the the surrounding, you know, recipients or clients.

SPEAKER 1
I think that was really cool. Do would you prefer a Amazon or a Starbucks gift card? I'll take a Amazon. Amazon? I'll just get your signature too.

SPEAKER 1
Okay.

My Note

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Mhmm.
That's kind of what their role is to figure out where to put the food. Mhmm.
How how did you feel about the whole process of making decisions?
It was very impersonal. You know, I I guess it would have been nice to know how much of the previous donations were actually utilized or preferred. Right? So if the recipient was had the capacity to distribute the different types of foods and donations Mhmm. And how receptive their their clients were.
Mhmm.
In your opinion, what does a fair allocation look like?
One that understands the needs of the recipient and the clients and tries their best to leverage what they have to meet those needs. When it doesn't well yeah. Okay.
Do you have any suggestions or any other ways you could see of doing this or anything that was unclear to you today?
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Experts in local food security would be the most important ones.
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Mhmm. So that's why I think Ford too has that's where their strength is that assume they know the needs of the the surrounding, you know, recipients or clients.
I think that was really cool. Do would you prefer a Amazon or a Starbucks gift card? I'll take a Amazon. Amazon? I'll just get your signature too.
Okay.

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